

New High School

New upscale housing developments built in suburban areas encompassing less expensive older communities. Some new homes were built in an optional area, the boundary between communities. In such an area, buyers were also informed. Over nearly ten years of development, more than five thousand new homes were built in the area, along with a new high school (NHS). During the construction, two local high schools, East High School (EHS) and West High School (WHS), opened their doors to students from the area. Upon completion of construction, the boundaries were drawn between EHS and WHS. Due to the limited number of spaces available, NHS could not accommodate every student wanting to attend. Students within the boundaries were automatically selected to attend. Students in optional areas were selected on a first-come, first-served and lottery basis. Some students from the outside boundaries were also able to maneuver their way into attending.

NHS was a high-tech high school, fully equipped with the latest technologies and a state-of-the-art learning environment. It had a maximum capacity of 1800 students and was already nearly full. It also anticipated many freshmen in the coming year. Most students attending NHS come from middle-class families whose parents are professionals and have college degrees. Parents' volunteering and participation in school activities were also high. Financial support and donations from the local community and private industry were also good. It also received substantial funding for computers, laptops, and network equipment. In addition, each student attending NHS was given a laptop to take home to support their educational needs. Furthermore, the school was chosen by unnamed University and private industry to conduct scientific research on students and technology.

On the contrary, EHS and WHS were among the worst-performing schools in the district, with high rates of dropout and turnover. The schools also faced financial, social, and economic difficulties. Parents' involvement in school activities was also low. The students' population was mostly of lower-income and minority families whose parents either completed high school or attended college.

The boundary was the main concern. The school district board has set up several meetings with the communities to address the issues. Most attendees were in the optional area and outside area, and they wanted NHS to accommodate their children. People living in the area fought to keep small class sizes and to keep only students in the area. People living in the optional area wanted the school to make room for their children, and some people living from the outside boundaries wanted the school to make room for their children too. Some had suggested the school build more classrooms and add classroom trailers.

Some parents from the outer boundaries had arranged accommodation for their children to attend NHS by renting a room in the area and using the address of a family or friend who lived there so their children could attend NHS. There were also cases where students had never lived at the residence.

The story of this drama, though, is largely about boundary-setting, but boiled down to three key issues: 1) quality education; 2) privileged and non-privileged students; 3) conflicts between communities.

Questions

1. One definition of fairness is everybody getting the same treatment. How do leaders define fairness in terms of public education, equality, and social class.
2. What leadership position has the power to decide who is eligible to attend NHS? What is the role of the school administrator? What is the role of the district board? Do parents have input into the decision-making process? Can EHS and WHS do anything here?
3. What leadership styles are best suited to handling this kind of situation? How can one measure fairness?

Although this is just a case study about school boundaries, it has raised some critical questions about fairness. More importantly, it's about getting a quality education, which often depends on where you live.

Usually, it's the ones who can afford to live in an area of a good school and students from lower-income and ethnic minorities are always being the ones left out or end up getting whatever's available. As this story has a portrait, it shows that quality education comes at a cost, even in public schools. In addition, parents in this case struggle to provide their children with a quality education. In a situation like this, people will look to leaders for guidance, problem-solving, and decision-making. Such leaders are expected to make difficult decisions, knowing in advance that there is no easy solution to the problem. Whatever decision he/she chooses that there will always be critics.

I want to start with a question of fairness. One meaning of fairness is everyone getting the same treatment. In capitalist society, we know that not everyone gets the same thing. Earnings also differ across the various classes of workers. Different people perform different job functions and pay varies by role. Highly trained professional white-collar workers earn more pay than people in blue-collar jobs, which include both factory and lower-level workers. This is the same as saying that a person with a college degree earns more pay than one without. It also depends on one's job function and is often directly related to education. In this case, people who can afford to buy a home in a good area can also attend the new school. Likewise, people want to attend a good school but might not live in the area, and so, you can't. However, if you can buy a home in the area, then you're welcome to attend. Certainly not everyone can afford to live in a prominent area as described in this case study. As for the question of fairness, people do understand what it is. People in the case study have accepted the fact that they are not living in the area and therefore, they have to accept the alternative of education, but many still try to give their children the best opportunity to quality education. There is a clear consequence of social injustice here. The poor and minority groups are legally being discriminated against and drifting further away from the opportunity to do better. As a leader, one is bound by legal and regulatory requirements, educational codes, and a professional code of ethics, but must also be fair.

I do believe that a leader has the power to make a difference. In this case, a leader can't legally change the boundaries, but there are many things one can do to bridge the gap between communities. Perhaps one can create a collaborative learning program for all schools, with each school taking pride in and ownership of its program. An outreach program would be helpful in assisting both community members and students. Such programs are tailored to the needs of struggling students, tutoring services, promoting community activities, sports, etc. One of the objectives is to give students a reason to believe in themselves and help them do better, resulting in the community doing better. I don't believe that any one group is more superior than the other groups. As a society, we need to measure success by how well people work together for the common good. A leader in this situation needs to be more open—Open Systems and Situational Theory. He/she may need to find a way to harmonize both the environment and its surrounding communities. Each school may operate independently, but both the schools and communities should be willing to listen to community input and opinion. The district board's job is to coordinate and oversee the progress. The school administrator works with the district board to develop a plan that meets the needs of all students and their communities. This should be executed to be mutually beneficial for all schools. The answer is equality of opportunity. Without equality, there is bound to be conflict, and it can only get worse.

In closing, this case study is not really about boundaries; it's about education and equality. More importantly, it's about the fairness in educational geography. The leadership styles best suited to handle this kind of situation include patience, good listener, good communicator, organizer, practical, personality, integrity, efficiency, fairness, humanity, focused, peacekeeper, problem solver, ethical, conflict resolution, pragmatic, and honest. He/she should be aware of multi-cultural and multi-ethnic differences. I think that this is hard to do, but little things add up to make big differences. Finally, he/she needs to promote education and social justice. As far as this story goes, there was no change to the boundaries and no new classroom.